

On the Pleasures of Reading

An essay in praise of the quiet hour

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I.

There is a particular hour, neither morning nor evening, when the house falls quiet and the lamp seems to draw the room a little closer. It is in this hour that a book becomes less an object and more a companion. The reader, settling in, performs a small and ancient ritual: the turning of the first page, the gentle squaring of the spine, the slow surrender of attention to another mind.

We do not read merely to be informed. If that were so, the encyclopaedia would be our only literature and the library a kind of warehouse. We read, rather, to be accompanied; to discover that a thought we believed peculiar to ourselves has been thought before, and thought more clearly, by a stranger separated from us by centuries and seas.

A good book asks little and gives much. It does not demand the bright attention of the screen, nor the constant flattery of the notification. It waits. It is patient in a way that the modern world has nearly forgotten how to be, and in waiting it teaches us, almost without our noticing, the lost art of patience itself.

II.

Consider the physical book: its weight in the hand, the faint scent of paper and binding, the small geography of a dog-eared corner. These are not incidental pleasures. They are the body of reading, and the body matters. To resume a book is to return to a place one has been, and the worn page is a kind of map.

But the digital page, too, has its quiet virtues. It remembers. It carries an entire shelf in a single slim pane of glass and asks nothing of the dusty corner. The trick, if there is one, is to make the new vessel as hospitable as the old; to give the wandering eye a margin to rest in, and the returning reader the exact line where he left off.

For there is no small cruelty in losing one's place. The reader who must hunt for the sentence he abandoned the night before loses not only time but the thread of feeling, the warmth that the page had gathered. A reader's tool should hold that warmth as carefully as a hand cupped around a candle.

III.

And so we come to the modest argument of this essay: that the manner of reading is not indifferent to the matter. A noisy room spoils a tender chapter. A cluttered page exhausts the eye. The reader deserves a room of his own, even if that room is only a rectangle of warm light on a screen, framed in the calm of unhurried type.

Let the margins be generous. Let the type be honest and old, the kind that has set ten thousand pages before this one. Let the page fill the width of attention and nothing more. And when the reader rises and goes about his day, let the book wait exactly where he left it, the ribbon still tucked between the pages.

This is all that reading asks of us, and all that we, in turn, might ask of the things we read upon: a little quiet, a little warmth, and the patience to be returned to.

Finis